

Grasslands

COOSA PRAIRIES BY BRAD WILSON



WHORLED SUNFLOWER
(*HELIANTHUS VERTICILLATUS*)
BY ALAN CRESSLER

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Grasslands are open, grassy habitats over shallow acidic or alkaline soils. Habitat characteristics may also include shallow soils and shrink-swell soils. They may be moist or dry, depending on the topographic setting. These small patch habitats are relatively rare in Georgia and are typically embedded within other landscapes that also include woodlands and savannas. Historically, the open nature of these communities was maintained by unique soil conditions, periodic fire, and large, grazing herbivores such as bison and elk.

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Grasslands are essential to forestry operations in Georgia, offering ecological, economic, and climate benefits. They provide habitat corridors for wildlife and pollinators, supporting biodiversity. Grasslands reduce wildfire risk by acting as natural firebreaks and are key areas for prescribed burning. They stabilize soil and filter runoff, protecting forest streams and watersheds. Used in silvopasture and as buffer zones, grasslands enhance sustainable land use. They also generate income through hunting leases and grazing. Grasslands store carbon in soils and recover quickly from drought, helping forests adapt to climate change. Integrating grasslands strengthens forest resilience and productivity.

Today, sustainable forestry recognizes the ecological importance of grasslands, and practices like BMPs, low-impact machinery, and prescribed fire are used to balance timber production with conservation. When managed properly, these grasslands offer restoration opportunities, balancing timber production with ecosystem recovery.

SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

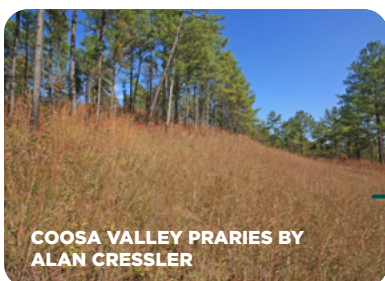
Acidic Meadows Over Sandstone or Shale

Calcareous Prairies (Coosa Valley Prairies)

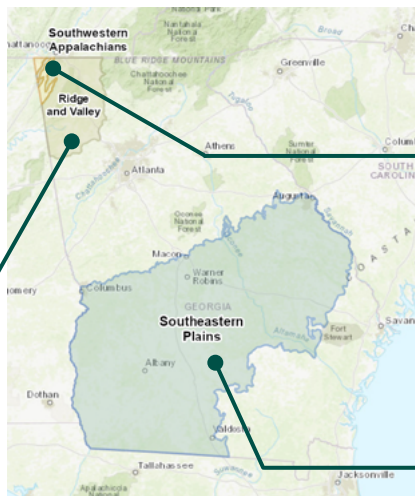
Black Belt Prairies

Southwestern Appalachians/
Ridge and Valley

Southeastern Plains



COOSA VALLEY PRARIES BY
ALAN CRESSLER



A FIRE MAINTAINED PRAIRIE
OVER ACID SOILS BY L. EDWARDS



BLACK BELT PRAIRIES BY
MUSEUM OF NATURAL
HISTORY AT AUBURN UNIVERSITY

THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Indiscriminate herbicide use or mechanical vegetation treatments can reduce plant biodiversity and negatively impact ecosystem function.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Clean vehicles, tractors, and equipment between sites if invasive species are present. If operations cannot be avoided in areas where invasive species are present, conduct operations in these areas last.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.
- Do not use these areas as logging decks, use old logging decks when possible or site decks in previously disturbed sites.
- If implementing prescribed burning, try to use existing boundary roads and natural features as fire breaks to minimize soil disturbance.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species
via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard
for more information and resources

